A 21-Month Business Plan for a 16-Year-Old IB DP1 Student in Mumbai

Short version. Start a **skill-based service business that bills in advance**. The default is a done-for-you "local digital presence" service for Mumbai salons, cafés, gyms and coaching classes, sold as a monthly retainer. Run it in the student's own name, with a parent signing as guardian. Keep family money at risk under **₹75,000 until the first 3 customers pay, ₹2 lakh until the business proves itself, and ₹10 lakh in total before age 18**. Define "job-replacing money" as **₹50,000 a month or more of after-tax profit in cash actually received, for 3 consecutive months** (Gate 4). Contracted-but-unpaid money never counts.

Honest odds (Section 6 shows the arithmetic). For a committed student who follows the plan:

- About **1–3%** reach job-replacing profit *while still in DP2 term* (before IB finals). The exam windows take out about half of DP2's months, so this is rare by design.
- About **5–7%** reach it by **31 August 2028**, in the summer after finals and before university starts.
- About **12–18%** reach it by the end of 2028, once exams are over and the student is 18.
- About **12–18%** hold ₹25k a month or more in profit in mid-2028.
- Most students end with ₹5–25k a month, a real selling skill, a credible university story and an intact IB score.

The plan is built so that these likely outcomes still count as wins. No plan that respects IB hours does much better before 18; the sections below say why. The ₹8M net worth is a safety net, not fuel. The worst realistic outcomes are losing a lot of family money or losing IB points, and the plan is designed around avoiding both.

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0. Assumptions (check these first; if one is wrong, see Section 10)

#	Assumption	If it's wrong
A1	Today is around October 2026. DP1 started June–August 2026. DP1 internal end-of-year exams fall around April–May 2027, DP2 mocks around December 2027–January 2028, and IB finals in **May 2028**. The student turns 18 sometime between late 2027 and late 2028.	Use the school's real calendar from day 1. Shifting dates is **not enough on its own**: the plan depends on *where the long holiday falls*, not when the year starts. **June-start schools** (long break around May, on top of DP1 exams) must use the Phase 3 fork in Section 5.
A2	The $8M (about ₹70 crore) is mostly **illiquid**: property, a family business, investments.	The plan still works, because it deliberately needs very little capital.
A3	The parents support the plan and will act as legal guardian on paperwork.	Without that, stop. A minor cannot safely run a business alone in India (Section 3).
A4	The student wants a strong IB result and probably university (India or abroad).	If not, the hour caps can loosen after May 2028, but not before.
A5	"Job-replacing" means a decent Mumbai graduate salary: **₹6–12 lakh a year, so ₹50k–1 lakh a month of after-tax profit**, not revenue.	If the family means ₹30 lakh a year or more, no plan for a full-time student gets there with real odds before 18. Say so at home.

#	Assumption	If it's wrong
A6	The student has no unusual existing asset (large audience, shipped app, professional-level skill).	Use the alternative tracks in Section 10.

Law and tax caveat. Indian rules on minors, tax, GST and professional advertising change often. **The Income-tax Act, 2025 replaced the 1961 Act from 1 April 2026 and renumbered its sections.** Old section numbers are cited below; ask the CA for the current equivalents. Everything legal here is a **starting brief for a CA or lawyer**, not a final answer.

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1. Why this business, and not the obvious alternatives

Each option is scored for *this* person: little time (IB), limited legal capacity (a minor), a lot of family capital (which tempts overspending), and a window of about 20 months. The probabilities are rough judgments from base rates, not measured data.

Option	P(first ₹ in 60 days)	P(≥ ₹50k/month after-tax profit by mid-2028)	Worst realistic loss	Fits IB hours?	Minor-law friction	Verdict
Local digital-presence retainer (Google Business Profile, WhatsApp Business catalogue, simple site, review replies) for salons, cafés, gyms, coaching classes	~70%	~5–7% (by Aug 2028)	₹50k–1L	Yes; async and batchable	Low; bill in advance	**Default**
Tutoring MYP / IGCSE / ICSE students	~80%	~2–4% (capped by hours)	~₹10k	Yes	Very low	**Best fallback.** Safe, low ceiling.
Freelance video editing / design for creators and D2C brands	~50%	~4–7%	~₹30k (tools)	Mostly	Most platforms need 18+	Good if the student already edits well
Micro-SaaS / app	~10%	~1–3%	Time, plus ₹1–5L if developers are hired	Poor	Low	Strong coders only; Section 10
D2C product brand with inventory	~40%	~1–3%	**₹5–30L**	Poor; daily fulfilment	Medium	**Avoid before 18**
YouTube / Instagram creator	~5%	~1–3%	Time	Medium	Platform rules	Side channel only
F&O, crypto, "trading"	n/a	Negative expectation	Unlimited	No	Minors can't trade F&O	**Banned**
Buying a franchise or existing business	n/a	~3–5%	**₹10L–1Cr**	No	High (minor can't sign)	**Banned** before 18

The ceilings are low across the board. The default does not win on ceiling. It wins because it holds up in almost every scenario:

1. **Demand is real and close by.** Mumbai has hundreds of thousands of small establishments with incomplete Google listings, unanswered reviews and no WhatsApp catalogue. The student can check this in one afternoon on Google Maps (Section 8, Day 3).
2. **Recurring revenue.** Retainers build month on month instead of resetting.
3. **Capital needed is tiny.** If it fails, the family loses less than a mid-range laptop costs.
4. **It is skill-based, which matters for tax** (Section 3): while the student does the work personally, the income can stay in the student's hands at ₹0 tax.
5. **It builds skills that carry over**: selling, pricing, delivering and operations.

Main threat (confidence: medium): AI tools keep pushing down the price of one-off website builds. So the offer is not "I build websites." It is "I keep your listing, replies and WhatsApp running every month and report the numbers." That is execution and accountability, which AI cheapens much less.

Why clinics are not the default (confidence: medium-high). Doctors work under professional-conduct rules on advertising and soliciting patients: the Indian Medical Council (Professional Conduct, Etiquette and Ethics) Regulations, 2002, which still apply in practice while the NMC's 2023 replacement regulations remain unsettled. Dentists are covered by the Dentists (Code of Ethics) Regulations, 2014, and physiotherapists have their own council guidance. A teenager running review drives and promotional broadcasts for a clinic can put the clinic's registration at risk. Clinics are therefore **optional, listing-accuracy work only** (correct hours, address, photos of the premises, phone number). There are no review campaigns, testimonials or broadcasts, and the student first checks the relevant council's current advertising rules.

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2. Hard rules (each one exists because a common failure happens without it)

Write these down, have the student and both parents sign them, and pin them up. Breaking one stops the business until a family review.

1. **IB comes first, and this is measured.**
    - **Baseline:** whatever grades the school actually issues first (the term-1 report or internal assessments, on the IB 1–7 scale or the school's scale).
    - **Trigger:** a 1-point drop in two subjects, a 2-point drop in one subject, a 3-point drop in total, or any written concern from a teacher or the DP coordinator.
    - **Action:** maintenance mode (existing clients only, no selling) until the next report shows recovery.
2. **Time caps** (log every hour in a shared sheet; unlogged hours count as over the cap):

Period	Cap	Selling allowed?
Normal term weeks	8 h/week (6 h/week in DP2)	Yes
School holidays	30 h/week, with Extended Essay hours blocked first	Yes

Period	Cap	Selling allowed?
3 weeks before DP1 internal exams, and during them	3 h/week	No
6 weeks before DP2 mocks, and during them	2 h/week	No
Mid-March 2028 to the end of IB finals	2 h/week	No

Travel to client sites counts toward the cap. In an Aug-start school, these windows touch about **6 of DP2's 10 months** (roughly November–January and March–May). The service contract is built around that fact (Phase 2, "exam-month clause").

3. **Money cap with stage gates (one schedule, used everywhere).** Cumulative family money: **₹75,000 until Gate 1; ₹2 lakh after Gate 1; ₹5 lakh after Gate 2; ₹10 lakh after Gate 3**, and never more than ₹10 lakh before age 18. **Evidence decides the budget, not net worth.**

4. **No credit to customers.** Setup fees are paid 100% upfront. Retainers are paid monthly **in advance**. A minor's contracts are void, so the student cannot chase a debt; billing in advance removes the problem.

5. **Banned before 18:** F&O or margin trading, crypto, MLM, paid "make money online" courses over ₹5,000, franchises, inventory imports, leases, lending to friends, and any "partnership" that asks the family for money.

    - SEBI's own studies found **about 9 in 10 individual F&O traders lost money** (FY22 and FY24).
    - A wealthy family with a teenage founder is a target. Treat every unsolicited "opportunity" as a sales pitch.

6. **No sensitive data.** Never collect health records, ID documents or card data for clients. The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 and its Rules are coming into force in phases, and a teenager should not be anyone's processor of sensitive data. Work on the client's *public-facing* presence only.

7. **Clean reviews only.** Ask *every* customer for a review in the same way, with no discounts, gifts or other incentives. Never filter which customers get asked ("review gating"), and never write, buy or swap reviews. Google's policies prohibit incentivised and gated reviews and can suspend the listing. In India, fake reviews also fall under consumer-protection enforcement and the BIS standard on online reviews (IS 19000:2022). One suspended client listing can end the business's reputation in a neighbourhood.

8. **Friends-and-family revenue doesn't count.** Money from relatives or parents' contacts is welcome, but it does **not** count toward any gate. Gates count only arm's-length customers.

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3. Legal and tax setup for a minor in India

Topic	Likely true (confidence)	What to do
Contracts	A minor's agreement is void (Indian Contract Act, 1872, s.11; *Mohori Bibee v Dharmodas Ghose*, 1903). **High.**	Use a one-page "service order" signed by the client and by a parent **as guardian**. Bill in advance.
Company / director	A minor in practice cannot be a director or get a DIN, and cannot be a full partner. **High.**	**Don't incorporate before 18.** Operate as an individual.
PAN	A minor can get a PAN through a guardian. **High.**	Apply on the Protean (NSDL) or UTIITSL portal for about ₹100.
Bank account	Since RBI's April 2025 directions, banks *may* let minors aged 10+ operate savings accounts independently, within bank-set limits. **Medium-high**; limits vary by bank.	Open a minor savings account with UPI. All business money goes through **this account only**. If the limits are too low, add a guardian-operated account.
Payment gateways and freelance platforms	Generally need an 18+ holder or business KYC. **Medium.**	Never open one in a parent's name to get around this. Use UPI or bank transfer from local clients until 18.
Clubbing of income	A minor's income is normally added to the higher-earning parent's income (old s.64(1A)). **Income from the minor's own manual work, skill, talent or specialised knowledge is excluded** and taxed as the minor's own. The 2025 Act carries this over. **Medium-high.**	Keep evidence that the student personally does the work: time logs, deliverables, client messages. Have the CA confirm before 31 March 2027.
Tax on the minor's own income	Under the new regime, total income up to **₹12 lakh** a year was effectively tax-free for FY 2025-26 through the s.87A rebate. **Medium-high; confirm for FY 2026-27.**	If the skill exception applies, profit up to about ₹1 lakh a month likely costs **₹0 in tax**. File the student's own ITR every year.
Clubbing trap	If other people do much of the delivery, the income may count as coming from others' labour, and be clubbed with the parent's income at about **31–39%** (30% slab plus surcharge and cess, depending on the parent's income). **Medium.**	Follow the decision rule below.
Turning 18	Clubbing applies only while the child is a minor. Income earned after the 18th birthday is the student's own whoever does the work. **Medium-high**; the CA confirms the split for the birthday year.	Schedule real scaling (hiring) for after 18.
GST	Registration is required once aggregate turnover passes **₹20 lakh a year for services** in Maharashtra. **High.**	Not needed before 18 on this plan. Set an alarm at ₹15 lakh rolling revenue.
Shop / establishment	Home-based with no employees: at most an intimation under Maharashtra's 2017 Act. **Medium.**	Ask the CA.
Labour law	Adolescents (14–18) may do non-hazardous work. Running your own home-based service outside school hours is fine. **High.**	Never hire anyone under 18.

Topic	Likely true (confidence)	What to do
IB CAS	Paid work generally does **not** count as CAS. **Medium-high.**	A *free* service for an NGO using the same skills may qualify. Ask the CAS coordinator.

The freelancer decision rule (decide this at the Phase 0 CA meeting, not later)

Freelancers are the only way past solo capacity (about 8 clients; Section 6). They can also cost the ₹0 tax treatment. Ask the CA this exact question: *"If the student personally does all selling, strategy, client contact, quality checks and monthly reporting, and an 18+ freelancer does only photo editing and post publishing, paid per task, does the skill exception still cover the student's net profit?"*

CA answer (put it in writing, even an email)	What the plan does before 18
Yes	Freelancers allowed from Phase 3. Cap of 12 clients. The student stays hands-on lead on every account.
Unclear	Freelancers only for **exam-crunch cover** (routine posting in the Rule 2 windows), with at most 15% of annual delivery hours done by others. Cap of 8 clients.
No	**Stay solo.** Cap of 8 clients until 18. Scale only with income earned after the 18th birthday.

Why "No" means "stay solo", with worked numbers:

Setup	Pre-tax monthly profit	Tax	After-tax
Solo: 8 clients at ₹7k average, all paid in advance, about ₹5k of tools and travel (a full-fee month)	~₹51k	₹0 (skill exception, under the ₹12L/year rebate)	**~₹51k**
With freelancers but clubbed: 12 clients at ₹6k = ₹72k, minus ~₹15k freelancers and ~₹5k costs	~₹52k	31–39% at the parent's rate	**~₹32–36k**

Under an unfavourable ruling, growing with freelancers *reduces* take-home money. So it is not done.

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4. Phase 0: Setup (19 October – 8 November 2026, about 3 weeks, about 10 hours)

Family steps

1. Hold a family meeting and sign the Section 2 rules. The **Phase 0–1 budget is ₹75,000 (hard cap until Gate 1)**, held by a parent and released against receipts.
2. Apply for the student's PAN and open the minor savings account with UPI.
3. Book a 1-hour CA consultation (₹5,000–15,000) with this question list:
    - Does the skill exception cover this business?
    - The freelancer question in Section 3, word for word.
    - What records do we keep?

    - Is there any Maharashtra professional-tax or shop-registration requirement?
    - How do we file the minor's ITR for FY 2026-27?
    - How is income split in the year the student turns 18?
    - When should we incorporate after 18, and as an OPC or a Pvt Ltd?
4. Set up one Google Sheet with tabs for Income, Expenses, Hours, Clients, Grades and Gates. Scan every receipt into a Drive folder.

Student steps

5. Record the grade baseline using whatever the school has issued so far. If nothing is issued until the term report, use teacher-reported internal assessment grades and replace them when the report arrives.
6. Learn the core skills in about 12 free hours:
    - Google Business Profile help centre, including **its review policies**
    - WhatsApp Business catalogue and quick replies
    - One website builder (Google Sites, Wix or Framer)
    - Canva
    - A neutral review-request QR flow (same request to every customer)
7. **Build the proof first:** do a full setup for **2 real businesses free of charge**. Use neighbourhood businesses, not relatives' shops.
    - Get *manager* access to each Google profile from the owner.
    - Take before and after screenshots and an audit score (Section 5) before and after.
    - **Start** the 30-day Insights record now. Calls, direction requests and views will be readable around mid-December and feed the Phase 2 price rise. Phase 1 pitches rely on audit scores and before/after screenshots, which exist on day 1.

Exit check (8 November 2026): PAN applied, account open, CA consulted with the freelancer answer recorded, 2 free setups done with before/after screenshots. If the CA says the structure is unworkable, switch to tutoring (Section 10).

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5. The phased plan with stage gates

Every gate states **revenue (MRR) and profit**, because the goal is profit. "Profit" means receipts minus all business costs (tools, printing, travel, freelancers), counting family-funded spending as a cost.

Phase 1: First paying customers (9 November 2026 – 10 January 2027; uses the Diwali and winter breaks, about 8–20 h/week)

Pick one area and one vertical. Choose an area within commuting distance (for example Bandra West, Andheri West or Powai). Start with **salons**, then cafés, gyms or coaching classes. These depend on local search, are visually photogenic, and can afford ₹3–8k a month.

Build a list of 100 prospects from Google Maps and score each on 6 checks:

- no or poor photos
- fewer than 50 reviews
- unanswered reviews
- wrong or missing hours

- no website
- no WhatsApp Business

Outreach

1. For the top 40, make a one-page **audit**: their score out of 6, 3 specific fixes, and a screenshot of a nearby competitor doing better.
2. Deliver it in person on a Saturday, with a parent nearby for the first visits, or on WhatsApp.
3. Script: *"I'm a student who helps [area] salons get more calls from Google. I checked your listing and found 3 things costing you customers. Here's the free audit. If you like, I'll fix all of it this week for ₹4,999, and I only start once you've approved the plan."*

Pilot offer: a one-time setup at **₹4,999**, paid upfront by UPI. It covers the listing overhaul, 20 edited photos, a WhatsApp catalogue, a one-page site and a review QR stand (about ₹300 to print).

Spend limits (inside the ₹75,000): at most ₹15,000 on tools and printing (₹10k tools and domains, ₹5k printing). At most ₹15,000 on one paid-ads test, and **only after** 2 sales have come from direct outreach.

Gate 1 (10 January 2027): 3 or more arm's-length paying clients, no refunds, Rule 1 not triggered.

- **Pass:** the cumulative cap rises from ₹75,000 to ₹2 lakh.
- **Fail:** one 4-week retry with a different vertical (to about 7 February). If that fails, switch to tutoring.
- **P(pass, including the retry) ≈ 55–65%** for a student who actually makes the 40 visits. Most failures come from not doing the outreach, not from missing demand.

Phase 2: From setups to retainers (11 January – about 14 March 2027 selling; then DP1 exam mode)

1. **Convert every setup client to a retainer.** Two tiers, both written into a one-page service order:

Tier	Price/month	Scope	Student time/month (after SOPs)
Standard	₹4,000–6,000	4 Google posts, replies to all reviews within 72 h (batched twice a week), 6 new photos, catalogue updates, one-page monthly report	~1.25 h
Plus	₹8,000–12,000	Standard, plus 2 WhatsApp broadcast campaigns to opted-in customers and a monthly 1-hour photo shoot on site	~2.5 h, plus a share of one shoot trip

Travel rule for Plus shoots. All clients are in one neighbourhood (Phase 1), so all Plus shoots for the month happen on **one Saturday, walking between clients**: one round trip of about 1.5–2 h in Mumbai traffic, logged as hours. A Plus client outside the cluster is either not taken or gets its shoot every 2 months.

Every service order includes an **"exam-month clause"**. It names, from the school's real calendar, **every month that overlaps a Rule 2 exam window**. In an Aug-start school that is up to 3 months in the rest of DP1 and **up to 6 months in DP2**; the order lists them

by name. In those months service runs in "lite" mode: review replies, the monthly report, and posts the student pre-writes during the preceding holiday and schedules. No shoots, broadcasts or new photos. The fee is **70%** in lite months (full fee only if a CA-approved backup does the full scope). Clients agree to this upfront, so no exam month breaks a promise. Say it plainly in the sales conversation: across a DP2 year, 6 lite months cost the client about 15% less than full service, and the student is a cheaper, more accountable option than an agency even so. Expect some clients to refuse this; they are not the right clients before 18.

2. **Raise prices** for new setups to **₹7,999–14,999** once 3 clients have before/after Insights numbers (available from mid-December).
3. **Systemise:** write an SOP for each recurring task, a client onboarding form and a report template. Batch all client work into **two fixed blocks a week** (for example Wednesday 6–8 pm and Saturday 9 am–1 pm).
4. **Sell hard while selling is allowed.** January to mid-March gives about 9 weeks at 8 h/week. Aim for one new client a week. Offer one free month for each referred client who stays 2 months.
5. **DP1 exam window** (3 weeks before and during internal exams, around April–May): 3 h/week, existing clients only, lite mode where the order allows.

Gate 2 (end of DP1 exams, about 31 May 2027): ₹25,000+ MRR from 6+ clients, about ₹20k+ monthly profit (₹25k minus ~₹5k costs) in the last full-fee month, no client over 30% of revenue, monthly churn under 15%, grades held.

- **Pass:** the family capital cap rises to ₹5 lakh.
- **Fail on revenue:** keep running what exists, with no added spending.
- **Fail on grades:** maintenance mode.
- **P(pass | Gate 1) ≈ 40–50%.**

Phase 3: Holiday leverage (the longest break between DP1 exams and DP2 term)

First, check which calendar the school runs. This phase depends on a block of holiday weeks *after* DP1 exams end.

School calendar	Phase 3 window	Business hours	Gate 3 date and target
Aug-start (most Mumbai IB schools): long break roughly June–July 2027	June – July 2027	EE 10 h/week first, then up to 20 h/week	**31 July 2027**: ₹40k MRR, ₹35k profit
June-start: DP2 term already running in June–July, long break eaten by DP1 exams	Normal DP2 term (6 h/week) June–September, then the **Diwali break** (about 2–3 weeks, October–November 2027) as the holiday block	6 h/week in term; up to 20 h/week in the Diwali break after EE	**15 November 2027**: ₹35k MRR, ₹30k profit (lower, because there is no 8-week block)

For the June-start route, the Phase 4 freelancer and price-lift steps below apply as written, but the conditional chance of passing Gate 3 is lower (about 25–35% instead of 35–45%), and the Section 6 odds should be cut by about a third. The family should know this before starting, not discover it in July.

Steps in the Phase 3 window:

1. Block **10 h/week for the Extended Essay first**, then the business hours from the table above.
2. Move the best clients up to Plus, and replace the lowest-paying client rather than just adding more.
3. Apply the **freelancer decision rule** (Section 3) exactly as the CA answered it. If freelancers are allowed, use 1–2 college students (18+) at ₹300–600 per task for editing and publishing. The student keeps sales, client contact, quality checks and reports.
4. Target **8 clients** (solo) or up to **12** (only if the CA said yes).

Gate 3 (date and targets from the table above; Aug-start: 31 July 2027, ₹40,000+ MRR, ₹35,000+ monthly profit), plus 2 months of costs held in the business account.

- **Pass:** the cap rises to ₹10 lakh. It is still mostly a reserve, not money to spend.
- **P(pass | Gate 2) ≈ 35–45%.**

Phase 4: Hold and lift price through DP2 (August 2027 – May 2028)

Growth in DP2 comes from **price and mix, not volume or new lines**:

- No new service lines or verticals.
- Client count stays at or below the cap.
- Raise existing clients 10% at their 12-month mark.
- Move clients from Standard to Plus.
- Replace churned or low-paying clients through referrals only.

The **time budget at 8 clients** (4 Standard, 4 Plus, about ₹7k average) shows this is deliverable, with travel counted:

Period	Cap (h/month)	Delivery (4 × 1.25 h + 4 × 2.5 h)	Shoot-day travel	Admin and reports	Selling (referrals only)	Total	Fits?
DP2 full-fee month (6 h/week)	~26	~15	~2	~5	~4	~26	Yes, at the cap; no slack
Lite month (any Rule 2 window, 2 h/week)	~9	~4 (replies; posts pre-written in the holiday before)	0 (no shoots)	~3	0	~7	Yes, because every such month is named in the exam-month clause
Pre-writing lite-month posts	Done in the preceding school holiday (about 6–8 h per lite stretch, inside the 30 h/week holiday cap)						Yes

The full-fee month has no slack. If logged hours run over for 2 months, the first fix is to move Plus shoots to every 2 months (cutting about 6 h); only if that fails does the plan drop a client.

Money in a lite month is lower and the plan says so: 8 clients at ₹7k × 70% = ₹39.2k, minus ~₹3k costs (no shoot travel) = **about ₹36k profit**. Over an Aug-start DP2 year (about 4 full and 6 lite months), that averages about ₹42k a month. So job-replacing profit is reachable *on average* by a strong student in DP2, but Gate 4's 3 consecutive full months mostly cannot happen until the exam windows end.

Two more steps for Phase 4:

1. Before mocks, write a **"hit by a bus" handbook**: SOPs, logins in a password manager shared with a parent, and every client's renewal date.
2. **University applications** (about August 2027 – January 2028): present real numbers (clients, MRR, profit, churn), what went wrong and what was learned. "₹40k MRR from 8 salons, sold door to door, no family money after month 3" is far more credible than "founded a startup", because admissions readers discount ventures funded by wealthy parents.

Gate 4: the actual goal (any 3 consecutive months up to 31 August 2028). ₹50,000 or more a month of after-tax profit, counted in cash actually received in the business account minus all costs. No allowance for contracted-but-unpaid money, and no averaging across months.

- **When it can realistically be passed:** in an Aug-start school, the only 3 consecutive full-fee months in DP2 are August–October 2027, which needs Gate-4-level revenue already in August 2027 (rare). For almost everyone, the passing window is **June–August 2028**, after finals, when Rule 2's exam caps are gone and the holiday cap applies. That is still before university starts, which is what "before leaving school" honestly means here.
- Solo route: 8 clients averaging ₹7k, all paid in advance = ₹56k cash, minus ~₹5k costs = **~₹51k**, at ₹0 tax if the skill exception holds. This has almost no margin: a single client paying ₹1k less, or a single missed payment, fails the month. So the working target for June 2028 is **8 clients averaging ₹7.5k** (one more Standard-to-Plus move, or the 10% anniversary rise), giving about ₹55k.
- Freelancer route: about 12 clients, only if the CA said yes.
- **P(pass by 31 August 2028 | Gate 3) ≈ 40–50%.**

Phase 5: Turning 18 and after exams (June – December 2028)

1. **Incorporate** if the business has made **₹30k or more a month in profit for 3 months**. This is the point where enforceable contracts and a current account pay for the compliance; it is *not* the job-replacing milestone.
    - Form an OPC or a Private Limited company, as the CA advises.
    - Move clients onto contracts in the company's name, now enforceable.
    - Open a current account and a payment gateway.
    - Register for GST when the CA says to, or by ₹20 lakh turnover.
2. **Scale now.** Income after 18 is the student's own whoever does the work, so the clubbing trap disappears. Hire freelancers freely, open a second area, and move to 15–25 clients if staying in Mumbai.
3. Decide between three paths:
    - **Grow full-time** (gap year or Indian university with light hours). This is where most of the 12–18% end-2028 odds come from.
    - **Run it alongside university** abroad with a local manager on profit share.

- **Sell or hand over the client book.** Small retainer books sell for roughly 1–2 years of profit, in a thin market.

4. **Only now** consider higher-ceiling ideas (a tool for the businesses the student now knows well), funded first by the business's own profit, and family capital only against a written plan with payback within 12 months.

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6. Money and odds

Family capital: when it is released and what it is for

Stage	Max cumulative family money	Allowed uses
Phase 0–1 (until Gate 1)	₹75,000 (hard cap)	CA (₹15k), tools and domains (₹10k), printing (₹5k), transport (₹10k), ads test (₹15k), buffer (₹20k)
After Gate 1	₹2,00,000	Laptop or camera only if the current one blocks work; tool subscriptions
After Gate 2	₹5,00,000	Working capital to pay freelancers before client receipts arrive (if allowed)
After Gate 3	₹10,00,000	Reserve; spending needs a one-page written case approved by a parent
After 18 + incorporation	Decide afresh	Only against a written plan with a payback date

Where the headline odds come from (committed student; each step is conditional on the one before):

Milestone	Conditional P	Cumulative P (middle and range)
Gate 1: 3 paying clients (by about February 2027 including retry)	55–65%	**~60%**
Gate 2: ₹25k MRR, about ₹20k profit (May 2027)	40–50%	**~27%** (22–32%)
Gate 3: ₹40k MRR, ₹35k profit (July 2027, Aug-start school)	35–45%	**~11%** (8–14%)
Gate 4: ₹50k after-tax *cash* profit for 3 consecutive months (by 31 August 2028)	40–50%	**~5%**
Plus late finishers who miss a gate date but catch up by summer 2028		+1–2% → **about 5–7% by 31 August 2028**
Of which: passed while still in DP2 term (needs August–October 2027 at full level)		**about 1–3%**
₹50k+ profit by December 2028 (post-18 scaling of everyone at Gate 2 or above)		**about 12–18%**
₹25k+ profit held in full-fee months at mid-2028: Gate 2 passers who hold or grow through DP2 (~27% × 45–55% ≈ 12–15%), plus a few who reach it late (~2–3%)		**about 12–18%**
₹1 lakh+ profit by mid-2028		**under 3%** (needs a team; post-18 only)

For a **June-start school**, cut the Gate 3 and later figures by about a third (no 8-week summer block; Section 5, Phase 3).

What each profit level needs:

Monthly profit (after tax)	What it takes	Feasible by
₹25,000	~6 clients at ~₹5k average (₹30k − ₹5k costs), solo, in a full-fee month	Mid-2027 to 2028
₹35,000	~8 clients at ~₹5k (₹40k − ₹5k), solo	Summer 2027 at the earliest
₹50,000 (job-replacing)	8 clients at ₹7–7.5k solo with ₹0 tax, all paid in advance, or 12 clients with CA-approved freelancers	Full-fee months only; in practice June–August 2028
₹1,00,000	20–25 clients with a team	After 18 only

The odds are for a student who follows the plan in full. If the student is less committed, cut each figure roughly in half. The most common pattern is a strong start that fades in DP2, which is why Phase 4 is "hold and lift price", not "grow".

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7. Early-warning system (30-minute family review on the first Sunday of each month)

Fill in this table every month. **Any red cell triggers its action automatically.**

Metric	Green	Red line	Automatic action
Grades vs baseline	Same or better	1-point drop in 2 subjects, 2 in one, 3 in total, or a teacher's concern	Maintenance mode
Hours vs Rule 2 cap (4-week average, travel included)	At or under	Over the cap 2 months running	First move Plus shoots to every 2 months; if still over the next month, drop the lowest-paying client
A month with any Rule 2 exam window that is *not* named as lite in a client's order	None	Any	Amend that order before the month starts, or pre-deliver the work in the holiday
Client count vs cap (8, or 12 with CA approval)	At or under	Over	No new sales until back under
Share of delivery hours done by others (CA "unclear" case)	≤ 15%	> 15%	Take work back or call the CA
Family money spent vs gate cap	Under 80%	Over 100%	Freeze spending; review
Largest client's share of revenue	Under 30%	Over 40%	Next month's selling goes to new clients only
Unpaid work delivered	₹0	Any	Stop work for that client until paid
Monthly churn	Under 10%	Over 20%	Interview lost clients; fix delivery before selling
Any review incentive, gating or fake review on a client account	None	Any	Stop and remove it immediately; tell the client
Rolling 12-month revenue	—	Over ₹15 lakh	CA call about GST

Metric	Green	Red line	Automatic action
Unsolicited "investment" or "partnership" offers	—	Any	A parent and the CA review it before any reply
Student's enthusiasm (1–10 self-rating)	6 or above	4 or below for 2 months	An honest conversation; stopping is allowed

Stopping is an acceptable outcome. A student who runs this for 6 months, earns ₹60k in total and stops with grades intact has **won**. They learnt to sell, which most graduates can't do.

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8. First 7 days (start now)

1. **Day 1:** print Section 2. Both parents and the student sign it. Record the grade baseline. Put the school's real exam calendar into the Rule 2 table, list every month it marks as lite, and note whether the school is Aug-start or June-start (this picks the Phase 3 route).
2. **Day 2:** apply for the PAN, book a bank appointment for the minor's account, and book the CA. Send the CA the freelancer question in advance.
3. **Day 3: the demand test.** Score 30 salons (or cafés) in the chosen area on the 6 checks. **If fewer than 10 of the 30 fail 3 or more checks, change area or vertical.**
4. **Days 4–5:** do Google's free Business Profile training, including the review policies. Set up WhatsApp Business on a **separate number** (a ₹200 prepaid SIM in a parent's name).
5. **Day 6:** walk into 2 nearby businesses and offer the free setup.
6. **Day 7:** first family review. Ask one question: *"Is anything here already in conflict with IB deadlines?"* Adjust.

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9. What the family should and shouldn't do with its wealth

Do:

- pay for the CA and a lawyer
- provide a quiet workspace and transport to client visits
- make introductions as a learning channel (not counted toward gates)
- fund a laptop if one is genuinely needed
- keep a ₹1–2 lakh "mistake budget" that isn't a big deal to lose

Don't:

- buy the student a business, franchise or shop
- fund paid ads at scale before the unit economics work
- open accounts on platforms in a parent's name to get around age rules
- do client work yourselves, because that weakens the skill-income tax position
- treat business revenue as pocket money

Separately, consider a small **investing education** in a guardian-run demat account: delivery-based index funds only, ₹50k–1 lakh, to teach compounding. Keep it fully separate from the business.

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10. If the student's profile is different (decision table)

If the student…	Switch the default to…	Change to the plan
Has strong Maths or Science grades (6–7) and likes explaining	**Tutoring** MYP 4–5 / IGCSE / ICSE students at ₹800–1,500 an hour, growing into batches of 3–5 at ₹600 per student per hour	No freelancers. Group batches are the only way to scale. Ceiling about ₹30–40k a month at 8 h/week. Exam windows: pause or pre-arrange cover.
Already codes well (has shipped a project)	Run the default service for 6 months, then build a small tool for your own clients' problem	Never build before 5 paying users are waiting. ₹0 for developers before 18.
Already edits video or designs at a professional level	Video and design retainers for Mumbai D2C brands and creators (₹15–40k a month per client)	Same rules: billing in advance, local clients, no platforms until 18. Fewer clients are needed, so the hour caps bind less.
Already has 10k+ engaged followers	Monetise through digital products or sponsorships, with a parent signing contracts	Follow ASCI influencer disclosure rules. Spend 20% of revenue on a CA and a contract template.
Insists on clinics as a niche	Listing-accuracy work only	No review drives, testimonials or broadcasts. Check the council's advertising rules first.
Isn't interested, and the family is pushing	**Don't start.**	Motivation predicts outcomes better than any plan. Revisit after 18.

Summary of the plan

- **Business:** a skill-based local digital-presence retainer for salons, cafés, gyms and coaching classes, billed in advance. Fallback: tutoring. Clinics: listing accuracy only.
- **Legal:** operate as an individual minor with a PAN and a minor savings account, guardian-signed service orders, no company and no platforms until 18. The CA's written answer on freelancers decides whether the business stays solo (8 clients) or grows to 12 before 18.
- **Money:** cumulative family money capped at ₹75k until Gate 1, ₹2 lakh after it, ₹5 lakh after Gate 2 and ₹10 lakh after Gate 3 (never more before 18), released through gates measured on arm's-length revenue *and* profit.
- **Time:** every exam window is a named "lite" month in each client's contract (about 6 of DP2's 10 months), billed at 70%, with travel counted in the hour caps.
- **Milestones:** 3 clients by January 2027. ₹25k MRR (about ₹20k profit) by the end of DP1 exams. ₹35k profit by July 2027 (November 2027 for June-start schools). **Gate 4, the actual goal of ₹50k after-tax cash profit for 3 consecutive months, realistically in June–August 2028.** Incorporate at ₹30k+ profit after 18.
- **Odds (committed student):** about 1–3% for job-replacing profit while still in DP2 term, about 5–7% by 31 August 2028, about 12–18% by end-2028, and about 12–18% holding ₹25k a month in mid-2028. The plan is designed so that the far more likely outcomes are still clearly good ones.